

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Emmett Shear, Founder, Softmax & Twitch **Released September 23, 2025**

Jessica: Carolynn, I'm really excited. Today, we are here in person with Emmett Shear, former founder and CEO of Twitch, but now founder and CEO of Softmax, which we wanna hear all about. We are at the Y Combinator Founder Mode Retreat, and so we're talking to people who know what they know what they're talking about
[\(00:00:00\)](#)

Carolynn: About this
[\(00:00:23\)](#)

Jessica: So but first, Emmett, I just wanna quickly hear about Softmax.
[\(00:00:24\)](#)

Emmett: Yeah. So after the whole, like, OpenAI thing, where I wound up I wound up doing that, CEO gave for record minimum time of, like, three days. So my I really feel like I did a I did a good job as being a CEO. If it only takes three days to be the CEO, you're really on top. Is that how long you were the CEO?
[\(00:00:28\)](#)

Carolynn: Why thought it was shorter? I thought it was, like, forty eight hours.
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Emmett: Like, it was it was it was it was fifty eight hours or something. Like
[\(00:00:47\)](#)

Carolynn: I love
[\(00:00:51\)](#)

Jessica: That. By the way, the day after that fifty eight hours, we ran your Social Radars interview that we had taped a few months before. It was he did. Perfect timing.
[\(00:00:51\)](#)

Emmett: That's so good. Okay.
[\(00:01:02\)](#)

Jessica: So after opening
[\(00:01:03\)](#)

Emmett: So basically, I felt like I'd gotten this message from the universe that was like, hey, Emmett. You should, like, pay attention to this AI thing. Because I kind of knew. I'd like if I'm like, oh, I should do some AI thing at some point. I was like, okay.
[\(00:01:04\)](#)

Okay. I guess I'm supposed to, like, do an AI thing. I guess I've messaged received. Fine. I'll go look into that.

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I'll sort of figure out what to do. I don't I didn't I didn't actually know what it was. I was just like, I guess I guess I'm supposed to do this. And so I really cared about this question of, like, how would you make an AI system that was sort of robustly aligned with humanity? What would it even what does it even mean?

What does it mean to build a system that stays in alignment with us? Because I had this sense that alignment was the right word, that in some sense, I wanted it to be on our side, but, I wanted to be aligned with it. And I wound up sort of coming down to this idea that, like, what alignment is about is about this question of or if you have two you have two beings or you have many beings, sometimes you have a bunch of individuals, and sometimes there's like a we. Like, we are here doing this. We care about we have goals.

And I can I can sense myself, like, I have a goal, but then sometimes we have goals, and I have my own goals? And I do the we goal instead of my goal, and it's it's because I am at some level, like, my family is me. My community is me. Like, there's we I am an individual, but I'm also part of this thing that's bigger than Yeah. Mhmm.

And that's sort of like this purpose and belonging comes from, and this comes from having agents, beings that can understand who they are, what they care about, and they can understand theory of mind style, who are the other agents around them, what do they care about, and can tell, like, are we part of the same thing? Like, because that's actually the question. Right? Is there a we here? Like, are we a collective?

What is the what's the right collective to care about? Because there's lots of collective you could care about.

Carolynn: I feel like this here is a very comfortable and clear we. That's why we all like being together.
[\(00:02:49\)](#)

Emmett: Yeah. Exactly. And I understand that YC in general forms this incredibly powerful sense of we. Right. And that that sense of we are we are starting these companies together is one of the most important things that YC does that YC is.
[\(00:02:55\)](#)

And so, like, how do you train an AI? How do you build or raise, grow an AI that that knows itself, that under has a model of itself that understands its goals, that understands has a model of us, understands our goals. And if it is if we are on its team and it is on our team, it can tell, like, oh, I'm part of this. I'm part of this team. And it can feel that care that we feel because it correctly infers from reality that that it is part of a team.

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Because that's not like you're not it's not you're not hallucinating when you think you're part of a like, you really know it really is your family. Yeah. It's like you know, it's not made up. That's real. And so that's what Softmax is dedicated to is how would you measure whether how do you measure whether agents are capable of this or not?

How do you measure if they are acting as a group? And then trying to make build simulations, build reinforcement learning simulations, basically, where we can test our theories and see if we can build an agent. The

Jessica:
[\(00:04:05\)](#)

The goal

Carolynn:
[\(00:04:05\)](#)

Is to teach it to know a we, to be a we.

Emmett:
[\(00:04:08\)](#)

Yeah. To raise it to be to know how to be a we. And it really is it wants you to up with eventually, you end up having to parent the agents because ultimately, no one can tell you who you are. That is something that everyone has to learn from themselves. Like, you can't you can't I can tell you what you are to me, but I can't tell you what it's like to be you because I'm not you.

I'm not I'm if I was in there, I could tell you, but I'm not then I would then I would be you. So you really you're gonna have to do it. Every you're and it's really it's really funny because I have two kids right now and, like, having kids, raising your kids, it's like, oh, like, this is the same. Like, you start and you're when you're born as a baby, you don't know who you are. Right.

And your job as a parent is to be a mirror and to and to give them a good mirror of themselves that helps them see themselves clearly. It's not your only job. One of your most important jobs is to help your kids see themselves clearly so that they know who they are and help them see you and help them see that they're hey. We're all part of this family together. And

Jessica:
[\(00:04:59\)](#)

That Yeah.

Emmett:
[\(00:05:00\)](#)

They don't infer that, it's bad. Yes. And, like and it's done all the time. It's totally it's a normal ordinary thing that we're actually very good at, but it's also something we're like, how do you engineer a system that has the capacity to learn in that way? And then how do what it would it mean to parent an AI?

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I don't think anyone knows. So that's the kind of what we're working on in the abstract.

Carolynn: [\(00:05:21\)](#) I I'm curious. What's the angle? Which I hesitate to use that expression with AI. But, like, let's say you're successful in measuring and understanding that you created Mhmm. A we.

Yeah. What do you want it to do once it's a we? Once it recognizes the we?

Emmett: [\(00:05:34\)](#) I want it I want the same thing for it that I want for my children, which is I want it to live a life of virtue and nobility where it both cares for itself and grows to be, you know, the happiest, most flourishing life it can have, and also cares about the greater wholes of which it's a part and acts with nobility, acts for tries to make a difference, cares. Because, like, what other thing could you ever wish for another being that you brought into this world other than, it has a good life and also purpose and belonging. And I don't want it to have some solipsistic good life on its own. That's actually that's not actually a good life. Nobody wants that.

I wanted to I wanted to see the truth that, like, we need it to and it needs us, and we're we're part of something together. That'd be the ideal. That is, in my mind, the bar for success. If what we produce are alignment benchmarks and ways of training agents where, that someone else uses to then train, I view that as a success. So we're gonna be launching things like benchmarks to help people see, are they succeeding at this?

Because ultimately Oh, wow. Ultimately for society, somebody has to.

Carolynn: [\(00:06:39\)](#) Right.

Emmett: [\(00:06:40\)](#) But I we sort of view it as a holistic system. Like, you can't you don't get to just pick pieces of it because, if you if the thing lacks the capacity, it won't learn it. If you don't have the right training environment, it won't have the capacity. If it doesn't have experience with peer with a high variety of you don't you don't just raise your kid as parents. You need peers.

You need you need it needs to know how to help other agents and help teach needs to needs to teach as well as to learn. So you need you need this very actually quite sophisticated environment. So we spend almost all of our time thinking about what's the learning environment, not what's the learning architecture. And, obviously, at some level, go pan you can't. They all go hand in hand.

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They connect to each other. But, like, but I'd say the we're almost like an inverted AI company that cares about the learning environment more and the, like, trying to make the agent into something specific less. And it's a it's been the most interesting work I've done in my life.

Jessica: I'm done. This sounds It's so fun. Interesting, and I bet you're having fun.
[\(00:07:38\)](#)

Emmett: Oh my god.
[\(00:07:42\)](#)

Jessica: It's so good. Started, and how big are you now?
[\(00:07:42\)](#)

Emmett: So we started it, jeez. Like so a year and a half ago, me and Adam Goldstein started, basically, with the question and, like, two employees and, like, trying to figure out, like, what all the things I'm saying now, we had a very a proto version of them, but I would not able to articulate them clearly. I was we were we were groping in the darkness.
[\(00:07:45\)](#)

Jessica: Okay.
[\(00:08:11\)](#)

Emmett: And we spent the next year roughly groping in the darkness and made a lot of progress and wound up. I like, I got to the point where I had this day where I was like, we were doing the next architecture design. Like, we need to reset our architecture. I'd be like, okay. We have the plan.
[\(00:08:11\)](#)

Now we know what we need to go do. We have here's the open questions. Here's the things we need to go measure. And then we invited, David, David Blumen, by the office to give us a talk on something, just sort of random. And he comes in, and he lays out this architecture he's been building for the past, you know, year and a half, two years that is, like, note for note, the thing that I had just articulated the team that we had to go build.

Wow. And it's is the weirdest synchronous thing has ever happened in my life. Wow. I don't I cannot explain it. I cannot explain it.

I mean, I can't explain it. I'm not talking about this shit all the time. So, of course, you heard about it. Almost It's not a coincidence at all. Yeah.

But it was weird.

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Jessica: Who's David Blumen?
[\(00:08:57\)](#)

Emmett: David Blumen, is my second cofounder.
[\(00:08:58\)](#)

Jessica: Okay.
[\(00:09:01\)](#)

Emmett: And he's a, an engineer who's at, you know, Google, Asana. Okay. And just, you know, one of the one of the best engineers I've ever worked with, but also, like, saw the same thing from a less theory point of view at the same time and just sort of, like, in parallel almost the same time we did sort of building in parallel, but where we took a theory and then it comes to the practice. He started the practice and it sort of come to the theory, and we kind of came together and, like, this was then so then at January this year, he joined the team. And so it's just seven months, basically, of, like, we have the full really, we started in some ways, we really started seven months ago.

Jessica: Yeah. Okay.
[\(00:09:33\)](#)

Emmett: And so that's, you know, that's where we are now.
[\(00:09:34\)](#)

Jessica: So you're seasoned now, Emmett. What have you learned about Founder Mode? And tell us if you can highlight any big mistakes or times when you went into Founder Mode. I'd be curious.

Emmett: Yeah. I think Founder Mode, when I when I think about what that means to me, it's like taking personal responsibility for the decisions the company makes and sort of treating the company as a full extension of you. And that that is not always a good idea because the company is both is and isn't that. Like, there's a way in which that is 100% true. The companies are reflections of their founders, reflections of their CEOs, and shying away from your responsibility to make decisions, to set direction, to take risks is like betraying the company and your customers and, like, yourself.

And they've always made a bunch of different people who are not you. And I think that there's this danger in treating it that way where you it becomes a company with just one brain. One brain, many hands.

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Carolynn: Yeah. Mhmm.
[\(00:10:39\)](#)

Emmett: And one brain, many hands is not it's just not a like, you don't have enough intelligence. You're you're just not smart enough. I guarantee it. You cannot pay attention to whole company at once. Like, even if you're really, really good, there's just a limit.

And so the my experience at Founder Mode has been what has been successful. I was to talk about, like, at Twitch. When I shifted into leading Twitch from Justin TV, and it was sort of this new thing, I went through this first phase of, like, doing a lot of the work myself. Mhmm. And that was that was kinda founder mode.

I was, like, really just in it every day, talking to customers, doing stuff. But then as the company started to grow, founder mode was the new thing. It wasn't stayed I had I had to completely stop programming, completely stop really doing that much product management, and I spent a lot of time on the weekly presentation every week. I spent a lot of time. I made the keynote, and I presented to the company every week.

Yeah. And because I needed everyone to be smart. I need everyone I needed to I couldn't I couldn't make all the decisions, and so I needed to, like I needed them to get it. And so I put a lot of effort into communicating to and this is when we were, like, a 100 people.

Carolynn: Yeah.
[\(00:11:42\)](#)

Emmett: Communicating to everyone in the company. When it's a 100 people, a 150 people, you can actually, with enough effort, I synchronize everyone. Like, I didn't have to be everywhere because they would make the decision I would have made because I've I have conveyed my mental model into their head, and they could just use how I see it. And but then plus but then plus also how they see it. They had a they had a good enough Emmett in their head that they knew what I would say, and they could, like, figure out how to integrate that in that local situation.

Carolynn: Yes. I think this is really good and interesting because this is, like, founder mode in terms of empowering others Yes. Versus in terms of, like, I have to be the one that takes all this on. So this is another, you know, iteration of how people view founder mode.

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Emmett: [\(00:12:25\)](#) Was it the thing is it's it's not, like, less egotistical. I got feedback from people because but because, basically, I was just gauging how well am I getting my mental like, I had the answer, and I was putting it into everyone else's head Yeah. Through repetition. Like, I just the things I cared about, I had a dissection for it. And then every week, I would talk about, like, who which streamer switched to Switch this week, and I talk about why.

And I would talk about why it was important that we get every streamer and every competing platform to switch to us and, like, how to think about when it was worth doing it when it wasn't, and I would target them. And, like, it was just every week over and over because I need everyone thinking about that that way. Yes. Or when we launched a product, I would talk about why whether it was successful or not. But it was really about me pushing out.

And then we grew, we grew, and we got to the point where the you just can't. Most people can't hold all the context got too big. And I the CEO's job is to be the holder of the context. The CEO's job fundamentally at the company wants many of many jobs, but one of the most important ones is everyone else has something has something they're responsible for. Yeah.

Mhmm. Even if, you know, the CFO is responsible for the CFO's area and not the other things. And they might hold the rest of the context, but you have the job of holding everything, being the context for the company. Yep. And the problem is what I learned is that, like, I spent all day loading the context into my head.

I just cannot at some point, the context gets too big. I couldn't even with effort jam the important parts of it to anybody's head. It's not possible. It was it was hard for me to keep up with all the context. Yeah.

And then I started to start so then you have to start breaking these up and delegating, releasing responsibility. And for first, that was good. At first, I delegated a lot, and it was actually, I think, really critical for the company that I had someone else who's a CTO. I didn't really understand our architecture direction, but I worked with him enough that when we went through a number of CEOs and they didn't they didn't work, didn't work, they're bad. And then I then we got someone really good.

We have the right person. And, like, every he was just a really good leader, and I could I could actually delegate. Mhmm. And then that delegation turned into, like I had got this idea that I think I think Brian talked about this, like, that, like, somehow, I wasn't supposed to override my people. I'd hired experts.

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I was supposed to let them do their job. Do their jobs as well. Like, like, when I didn't like how something felt or where I was taking the company, that I should crush down that that concern and not act on it. And that was a mistake. Like

Carolynn: That's sort of
[\(00:14:44\)](#)

Emmett: I allowed people who were, I think, well meaning, but who weren't me and who didn't really understand what we were doing because, actually, no one but the CEO ever really understands what's going on because it's not their job. That's that's my job. And I aggregate I, like, I did not I was failing in my responsibility to the company as the holder of the context to override people when they were wrong, to make sure that they the things were correct in the in the side of the context. Because it one of your jobs is to grow people and to delegate outside. One of jobs is to make sure and to know to have the discernment to know, is this the kind of decision that we have to get right, or is this the kind of decision where it's actually okay if we screw it up and it can be a learning this can be a learning experience for somebody.

Because there are decisions that can be learning experiences for other people. That's how I learned that's how I learned all this stuff is I made a lot of mistakes, and I got to learn from them.

Jessica: Yes.
[\(00:15:33\)](#)

Emmett: But, like, there's a lot of decisions that are not that are you actually do need to make this decision correctly. Then Yeah. There's more of those than you think. It is important
[\(00:15:34\)](#)

Jessica: Yeah.
[\(00:15:41\)](#)

Emmett: To make decisions right. And I just, at some point, I kind of realized, like, oh, I have to I can't have a head of product, really. Like, I have to be the head of product. I can't expect anyone who doesn't have all the context to make to make these decisions. Although I did I did learn something that was, like, really interesting.
[\(00:15:42\)](#)

This is incredible law, Conway's law. Conway's Law says organizations, products always reflect the information flows within those organizations. The structure of that product reflects the information flows in the organizations. If you have a communities team and a videos team, I will go to your website, and you will find a communities page and a videos page. I guarantee you every time.

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Jessica:
[\(00:16:21\)](#)

Okay.

Emmett:
[\(00:16:22\)](#)

And that's because if you're both shipping to the same thing, you have to be coordinated, which means you have information flows between your teams. If you don't, you keep stepping on each other's toes.

Jessica:
[\(00:16:32\)](#)

Right. Yeah.

Emmett:
[\(00:16:33\)](#)

And so you can have two teams if they're, like, deeply interconnected, then you don't really have two teams. You only have one Right. Where you've labeled half the people video or community. But, like but if you have two teams that are actually separate in any way, they have to have separate things. And so the only way to fix that as a CEO, you have to have two tools.

One is you can be you are the join point. If you personally take accountability, you become the information flow thing that that merges the two pages. You basically have to design the thing.

Carolynn:
[\(00:17:03\)](#)

Because you're not gonna look at two pages. You're You'd much rather look

Emmett:
[\(00:17:05\)](#)

At One. Right. Well and because you are integrating all the information from the video team and from the community team, and therefore, you can make

Jessica:
[\(00:17:11\)](#)

Yeah.

Emmett:
[\(00:17:11\)](#)

The correct contextual decision. Mhmm. Or you have a second tool at your disposal. I think people in Founder Mode are way under use this. If you wanna merge two pages of website, you just reorg your team.

Like

Jessica:
[\(00:17:22\)](#)

Reorg the

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Emmett:
[\(00:17:23\)](#) Team? Yeah. The easiest way to change the website, if you think that, oh, we have these two pages. I want them to be one, if these one page, I want it to be two, just reorg your company.

Carolynn:
[\(00:17:30\)](#) Give them different titles.

Emmett:
[\(00:17:31\)](#) Yeah. Team different names. If you have two if you have one team, you have one page. If you had two teams, have two pages. And it's so funny to watch it happen because, like, they'll come to the conclusion themselves, and they'll be right.

That's the logical thing for them to do.

Carolynn:
[\(00:17:41\)](#) This is Conway's Law.

Emmett:
[\(00:17:42\)](#) Conway's Law. Yeah. This guy this business this, you know, organization theorist from, like, the seventies and eighties. So the Cybernetics people, which we're really into at Softmax now.

Jessica:
[\(00:17:52\)](#) Okay.

Emmett:
[\(00:17:52\)](#) Although, I knew about this at Twitch, I tested it a couple times. Not that much. I really learned it, like, later on in my Twitch career, so I didn't didn't get to use as much as I'd like, but I tested it. It definitely works.

Jessica:
[\(00:18:01\)](#) And you'll use it at Softmax?

Emmett:
[\(00:18:02\)](#) Oh, you use it? A 100%. We're using it very deeply at Softmax.

Carolynn:
[\(00:18:04\)](#) I have ideas about how to use it too.

Emmett:
[\(00:18:06\)](#) It's it is That's a great It is great. And the thing is that people in Founder Mode really people talk about being scared of taking product risks stuff and overwriting people on product. But what you're really scared of is overwriting people on or, yeah, I think I tend to think about things in companies actually very people led way. It's weird because I'm a systems person. Yeah.

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But I, I'm a systems person whose primary medium I like to think is people. Like, the systems I care most about have always been people systems.

Carolynn:
[\(00:18:30\)](#)

Yeah. Okay.

Emmett:
[\(00:18:31\)](#)

How is it that people systematically relate? And so I'm I actually I for me, Founder Mode is mostly about the willingness to be like, we're gonna have a team focused on this. Like, I'm going to I'm going to decide. No. We're not I we're we're putting these things together.

We're splitting them apart. And, like, if you set the expect if you set the expectations right, the people are okay with that because they understand that the goal is to have the teams that reflect the work that needs to be done. Yeah. Not like it's not like it's not because you're anyone's succeeding or failing. It's about it's about what you can the cool thing on common law is it works even if you explain it.

It doesn't matter. It's a law. It doesn't knowing about it doesn't change anything. You can you can know what's happening, and it still works. And so, like, and there's no clear in some way, you could also see it normatively.

There's no clearer commitment to we're going to merge these two products into the same thing than to merge the teams. Yeah. How else can you say to the company so clearly, I'm serious? And so that's Yeah. That I think that that for me, that's that is the I people in founder mode, there's often this really emphasis on, like, I'm gonna make a lot of the detailed decisions.

And that can be right. There's a there are products or situations where that is where leadership lies. That's what you do need to do. And I did that at Twitch also. Mhmm.

But I think the maybe the thing I've let heard less that I would encourage founders to think about is, like, what if you treated your organization's structure, your communication to the company, your people leaders your leadership with the people with as much seriousness as you treated the product? And I find that, like, that takes it's a little bit of a weird feeling at first. It's ideally, I'm gonna spend I'm gonna make a keynote. I'm gonna spend three hours every week building a keynote. But, like, no.

Because if I do that, it's gonna be good, and it's gonna be clear. Yeah. And I have way more amplification of my work there.

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Jessica: Yeah.
[\(00:20:19\)](#)

Emmett: Sometimes. Only if the thing you if the thing you need is to be at Twitch, the big thing you need to do is to be smart all over. I needed every individual negotiation to be smart. And so that's I can't I can't be in all the negotiations, so I have to make the team smart. If what you're doing is building a product with, like, two surfaces, and those surfaces have to be right Mhmm.

Like, I think actually Airbnb is good example. It's like the checkout experience and, like, the lit like, those experiences have to be right. Yeah. And if they're not right, it doesn't matter if you're smart all over and the team that's pitching the people is good. You're just not gonna succeed.

Yeah. Whereas on Twitch, the core thing was kind of was working. We need and so it but I think that that's like a it's something people should they should reach for as a tool more often.

Jessica: Yeah. Okay. I love it. Emmett, it's such a treat to have you. I'm not kidding.
[\(00:20:59\)](#)

It's so nice to hear about Softmax and to hear your thoughts on Founder Mode. And I hope someday you can come back on the Social Radars and talk about Softmax. Yeah.

Emmett: I'd love to.
[\(00:21:15\)](#)

Carolynn: That would be fantastic.
[\(00:21:15\)](#)

Jessica: The timing
[\(00:21:16\)](#)

Emmett: Is
[\(00:21:17\)](#)

Jessica: Right.
[\(00:21:17\)](#)

Emmett: Yeah. Absolutely.
[\(00:21:17\)](#)

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Jessica: Thank you, guys. Walk.
[\(00:21:18\)](#)

Carolynn: Thank you, Emmett. Thanks, Emmett. Bye. Bye.
[\(00:21:19\)](#)